

NCWIT Selects 2024 AiC Impact Award Recipients



The NCWIT Aspirations in Computing (AiC) Impact Award honors Aspirations in Computing (AiC)

Community members and TECHNOLOchicas for their incredible work to ultimately encourage girls, women, genderqueer, and non-binary people of all ages to contribute their unique perspectives and ideas to future innovations. Award recipients are selected based on their efforts to build and creatively offer hands-on learning opportunities in computing and career exploration and to bring together advocates and allies of various backgrounds through computing-related events and community groups.

Meet the #NCWITAiC24 Impact Award Recipients

Laasya Aki (she/her)

CODEify

Laasya co-founded CODEify, a nonprofit dedicated to increasing minority representation in tech through accessible coding education. CODEify offers multiple resources like coding classes and a blog. Aki believes that technology holds many opportunities, and it is important that they are open to everyone, which is why she co-founded CODEify.

Sophia Al-Halaseh (she/her)

Beyond the Box Movement

Sophia started the Beyond the Box Movement, a club to raise expectations for teens through meaningful opportunities like volunteering, collaborating with professionals, and attending and hosting events. Sophia is currently working towards turning her club into a nonprofit.



Lekha Anand (she/her)

Girls Who Code Summit

Like the trailblazing female role models who inspired her, Lekha strives to make STEM a space that is both accessible and interesting for young girls and underrepresented minority groups. As the Vice President of her high school's Girls Who Code, she dedicates many hours to making every club meeting as welcoming and engaging as possible. Her favorite part, however, is organizing the Summit, an annual day-long event that introduces hundreds of local elementary and middle school girls to coding through fun, interdisciplinary projects led by high school mentors. Aside from being heavily involved in anti-youth tobacco initiatives in her community, Lekha also runs the podcast "Dame Good at STEM," which features interviews with inspiring women in various STEM careers.



Advika Arya (she/her)

We Succeed Together

Advika founded We Succeed Together, an NGO dedicated to ensuring that all children, especially those underprivileged, have access to the resources needed for an education. She works with orphanages across the world, firsthand seeing the power of computing. She hopes to ensure that everyone will also be able to experience the same, therefore helping them pursue their education.



Sagana Chattanathan (she/her)

TechxNova

Sagana founded TechxNova, an educational 501(c)(3) non-profit organization dedicated to empowering underrepresented communities, including girls, senior citizens, and low-income students in computer and space sciences. By teaching free boot camps and classes in topics like machine learning, coding, astrophysics, cosmology, and more, she's been able to promote inclusive, equitable learning opportunities for individuals to find their passions in STEM. Additionally, she organized TechxNova Hacks, a global hackathon for female and non-binary students, with participants from over 30 countries.



Jensen Coonradt (they/them)

STEM Club Founder & President

From creating a device to prevent frozen pipes to an electronic recycling bin that rewards students, Jensen leverages their love of coding and engineering to develop innovative solutions. This passion led them to start a STEM club, where they guided a diverse group of entrepreneurial students in solving community problems through invention. Leading their team to develop a backpack using ultrasonics and neuroplasticity to assist people with visual impairments, they advanced to the Samsung Solve Challenge national finals, winning \$65,000 to fund their high school's STEM department. This funding enabled the construction of a student maker space, which over 1,000 students have used to bring their ideas to life.



Smera Dhananjaya (she/her)

Genxl

Smera co-founded Genxl, a nonprofit organization dedicated to empowering the next generation through education and technology. With a network of 51,500 students and 2,100+ volunteers, they've established 50 chapters globally, certified over 5,000,000 volunteer hours, and partnered with industry leaders like Apple, Google, and MIT Scratch. Genxl's initiatives, including speaker series and summits, aim to inspire and equip youth with the skills to succeed in computing and beyond. Driven by the belief that access to technology and education



can transform lives, Genxl strives to create opportunities for all, especially those in underrepresented communities.

Elianah Dollar-Simmons (she/her)

Hack Club's "Days of Service" Initiative

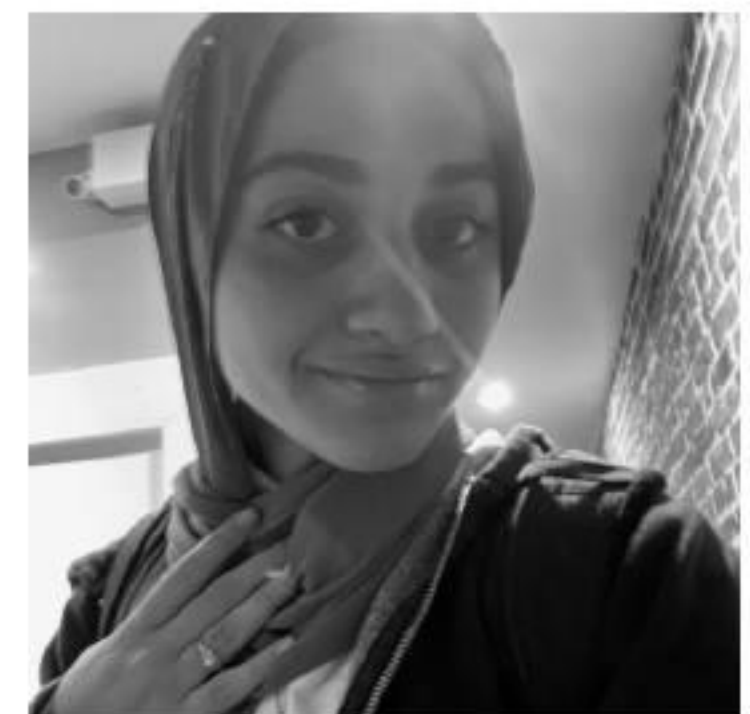
Elianah is a rising junior who has traveled the United States to bring coding to girls and gender minorities, inspiring them to find their future career paths in STEM. From Seattle to Austin, she's taught coding workshops for various skills using JavaScript, such as creating generative art that can be drawn using hardware and developing 8-bit video games for handheld consoles. She's helped to engage Girl Scouts, local school districts, Girls Who Code chapters, and foster care families in computer science, spreading the Hack Club message that anyone can learn to code by learning to create. Through her work, Elianah helps to empower girls, especially girls of color, to see themselves in technological spaces. She is currently working on introducing a new data science workshop in Python into the initiative, crafting a Girls in Tech Summit for later this year, and has hopes to one day bring a Day of Service to her home state of Minnesota.



Mariam El-Hadik (she/her)

Girls Who Code Chapter Founder and NeuroConnect App Co-Creator

Mariam El-Hadik, a rising senior, is dedicated to empowering young women in technology as the founder and president of her school's Girls Who Code chapter. She co-created an innovative app, NeuroConnect, that educates users on brain health and highlights its importance. Mariam's passion for computing is driven by a desire to make technology accessible and impactful for all, inspiring others to pursue a future in this dynamic field. Her initiatives aim to break barriers and foster a community of diverse, forward-thinking innovators.



Azra Emekci (she/her)

CodeSisters Club

Azra is passionate about empowering everyone to pursue computer science through CodeSisters

Club. Azra hopes to create inclusive spaces where students in grades 4 through 6 can learn and grow in STEM, guided by supportive mentors in high school who foster a sense of sisterhood and community. Seeing students' confidence and excitement as they discover the possibilities of computing fuels her commitment to this mission.



Sophia Evans (she/her)

Teens and Tech

Sophia's goal is to get more teenagers, especially girls, interested in STEM. As an intern at Hack Club, Sophia helps organize hackathons for high school girls in places like NYC, Toronto, and Boston. As a Teen Advisory Board member at Techgirlz, a Girls Who Code club leader, and an online hackathon lead organizer, Sophia has brought over 300 girls and teens together to learn more about technology.



Victoria Glossip (she/her)

Igniting Interest in Coding Across America

Motivated by her lifelong passion for coding and dedication to inspiring others, Victoria founded the Bit by Bit Coding Club at her former middle school and launched a WiSTEM Chapter at her current high school. Victoria's local successes propelled her to pursue greater challenges, expanding her initiative nationwide through her involvement with the nonprofit organization CODEify as Director of Outreach. She actively promotes their free coding classes through teaching, hosting, and monitoring classes, coordinating outreach efforts among team members, managing new tutors' onboarding, and recruiting students. Leveraging her web development and computer programming certifications, Victoria recently joined WiSTEM's global leadership team as the Front-End Website Manager. In this role, she will collaborate with WiSTEM to achieve their goals of promoting women in STEM by ensuring their website effectively communicates the organization's values and goals.



Riya Hegde (she/her)

Python Pals

Inspired by her own experience as one of the only girls in her computer science courses, Riya founded Python Pals with the ambitious goal of bridging the gender gap in computer science by teaching middle school girls how to code. Through this initiative, she taught 14 coding workshops, reaching over 80 middle school girls both locally and internationally, in collaboration with the Oakwood Indian School in Kundapur, India. Additionally, she partnered with a local youth shelter to provide coding workshops to the teenagers residing there, further broadening the program's impact. As Python Pals continues to expand, she created the Python Pals podcast to inspire a larger audience as she interviews experts in the field of computer science about their incredible journeys.



Remley Hooker (she/her)

Strong Stripes

Remley Hooker started her nonprofit, Strong Stripes, because of the difficulties she faced in STEM due to her rare disease, McCune Albright Syndrome. Strong Stripes helps kids and teens by providing STEM opportunities like internships, awards, and virtual sessions. These opportunities help members feel like there is a place for them in STEM and encourage them to keep going.



Lauren Jene (she/her)

Gatorbotics and Gear Up!

Lauren is the Programming Lead of FRC Team 1700, Gatorbotics, which is a girls' team based in the San Francisco Bay Area. In this role, she leads the programming subteam, teaching programming skills from the ground up to over 30 team members each year. Confronted by a lack of accessible robotics curriculum in our community, Gatorbotics designed a low-cost robotics curriculum, Gear Up!, that has been taught to over 850 kids through summer camps, after-school programs, and drop-in public library workshops since the program's start in 2021. Inspired by her experience scaling Gear Up!, Lauren has served as a mentor to these programs over many seasons, teaching fundamental skills at varying experience levels and encouraging students to show up authentically in STEM. Gatorbotics is driven by the mission to



empower underrepresented youth and has been recognized three consecutive times with FRC World Championship qualifying awards, the Engineering Inspiration and Impact Awards, which are the highest awards in the FIRST Competition.

Varini Kadakia (she/her)

STEM and Art

Varini, a junior in high school, is the founder of STEM and Art, a nonprofit focused on spreading STEM education to underprivileged places around the world. So far, Varini has hosted workshops within Haiti and Nepal, teaching students about the basics of Python programming to high schoolers and teaching Math Olympiad level math to elementary schoolers. Within an ever-changing society, her goal is to help open STEM pathways for these students, possibly inspiring innovations that can change the world. Her inspiration comes from her background in STEM and her desire to share the knowledge she has received with those who might not have the same opportunities as her.



Sabreen Khanikar (she/her)

CAT[APP]ULT Coding Program and Hackathon

Sabreen, an incoming freshman at UC Berkeley, had a critical observation: despite widespread interest among middle schoolers in app development, educational opportunities in coding and entrepreneurship are often lacking. Inspired by this gap, Sabreen launched CAT[APP]ULT, a coding program to ignite students' passion for technology and business through coding apps focused on global issues. Her passion for computer science grew from experiencing its potential across interdisciplinary fields, driving her advocacy of computer science education for underrepresented groups through CAT[APP]ULT. By integrating real-world challenges with hands-on learning, CAT[APP]ULT not only equipped students with essential skills but also fostered a pathway to future careers in technology and entrepreneurship.



Suhani Khare (she/her)

SparkLearn

Suhani, a rising senior, founded an initiative called SparkLearn in November of 2023 to address the

critical gap in educational accessibility for children in foster homes. Having witnessed the challenges these children face, including minimal funding and limited access to quality education, Suhani felt compelled to take action. Through organizing SparkLearn, she aimed to provide these children with fundamental computer skills and insights into programming, STEM fields, and future career opportunities. Her core belief is that education, primarily the quality of education, should be accessible for individuals of all backgrounds, and the opportunities in store for their futures through technology are just the beginning.



Anagha Krishnan (she/her)

Science Unlocked

Anagha Krishnan is a PhD candidate in computational biology who developed Science Unlocked with her co-founder, Hannah Dada, to address a lack of hands-on science education in carceral facilities. Science Unlocked provides monthly hands-on science initiatives (spanning fields like biology, chemistry, computer science, and engineering) to young men and women at the DC youth carceral facility. Over the past two years, they have provided over twenty-five demos to over 250 high-risk youth. Learn more about Science Unlocked [here](#).



Anna Krolik (she/her)

Programming and Robotics Education for Underprivileged Children and Students Affected by World Conflicts

Inspired by the growing efforts to promote STEM equity, Anna is dedicated to fostering a passion for computing and robotics among underrepresented communities. As captain of her robotics team, she developed a robotics programming curriculum for underprivileged students in San Diego, where they learn to control Raspberry Pi robots in Python. Internationally, Anna teaches a Computer Aided Design curriculum to Ukrainian refugee children in Poland, providing them with valuable skills and a sense of normalcy amid the turmoil of displacement. Through these initiatives, Anna creates opportunities for learning and growth, enabling everyone to explore and thrive in STEM.



Paridhi Latawa (she/her)

NCWITAiC Campus Rep; MIT PKG Center Ambassador; SparkED NPO Founder; MIT Sandbox Innovation Fund-supported Team Founding Member

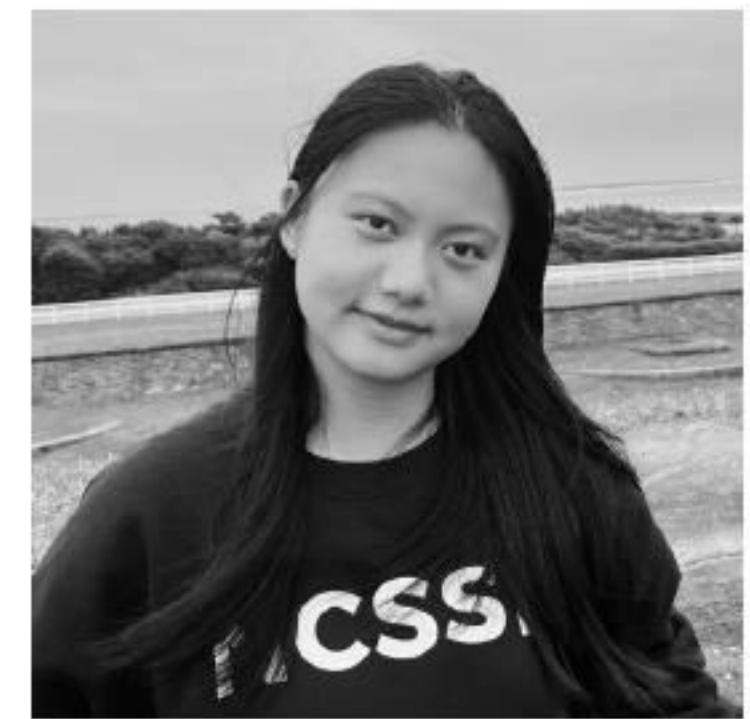


As a student at MIT and in high school, Paridhi has strived to lead service initiatives and activities that encourage diversity, equity, and inclusion. As an NCWIT Campus Ambassador at MIT, an MIT Priscilla King Gray Public Service Center Ambassador, the Founder and Executive Director of the nonprofit organization SparkED, & Founding Member of an MIT Sandbox Innovation Fund Team, Paridhi has organized and led impactful programs across computing, biology, and education equity to serve the community.

Hao (Lily) Li (she/her)

Global Science and Medicine

Lily is the founder and CEO of Global Science and Medicine, an initiative dedicated to exposing diverse students worldwide to STEM opportunities and empowering them to be the next generation of change-makers. In 2023, Lily and her team organized a free virtual STEM Summer Camp that engaged over 100 students from more than 20 countries through interactive sessions with professionals from various STEM fields. The initiative also established STEM-related clubs, such as the Computer Science Club and Medical Journal Club, where students explore their interests, work on projects, and connect with peers globally. Lily finds her work rewarding as she watches students continue to pursue their passion and grow confident in STEM, fostering an inclusive and equitable future for all students.



Katelyn Liu (she/her)

Wow! That's STEM and Robotics Mentorship

Fueled by her interest and experiences in robotics and science, Katelyn founded the initiative Wow! That's STEM, providing students with collaborative opportunities and an accessible gateway into STEM. She hosts hands-on workshops with an original curriculum on topics from ecology to engineering and robotics. As a co-captain and programmer on her FIRST Tech Challenge robotics team, she fosters and ensures collaboration on her team, writes software for robotics systems, and conducts community outreach. Through these outreach efforts, Katelyn connects students and

families to form their own FIRST Lego League robotics teams and provides ongoing mentorship. She runs workshops and summer camps with her teammates, introducing girls to robotics. Katelyn has also been recognized for her research at the intersection of ecology and computer science and continues to pursue scientific research in the field.



Grace Magny-Fokam (she/her)

Folia Technologies

Grace Magny-Fokam is a 19-year-old AI researcher, UN climate consultant, and the Founder and Executive Director of Folia Technologies, a youth-led 501(c)3 nonprofit research organization dedicated to creating AI solutions for agricultural and environmental challenges. Founded in 2022 with a vision to empower young



leaders, Folia aims to accelerate environmental action, drive systemic policy change, and empower communities worldwide to take action by leveraging science, technology, and innovation. As a science communicator, Grace has spoken to over 10,000 people about the immense potential of AI in social justice and sustainability.

Daniela Markazi (she/her)

University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign (UIUC) Puerto Rico Disaster Relief Program

As a first-generation graduate student, woman of color, and NCWIT Aspirations in Computing National Award Winner, Daniela has dedicated over a decade of her life to championing diversity in STEM, with a special focus on empowering women and young students from marginalized backgrounds. Her work particularly targets disaster relief and resilience in Puerto Rican communities, creating computing and engineering-based opportunities for university students, both in Puerto Rico and across the United States. Within the UIUC Puerto Rico Disaster Relief Program, where she has served as the Student Leader since its inception in 2018, Daniela has helped to create a diverse array of activities: workshops, research programs, study abroad opportunities, mentorship sessions, and three university courses. These initiatives immerse students in computing and



engineering-based research projects for a semester (or more), culminating in the application of their projects in underserved communities near San Juan, Puerto Rico, and provide students with a unique opportunity to engage in community-based STEM and apply their computer science, data science, engineering, and design skills in real-world scenarios.

Naina Misra (she/her)

Increasing Interest in Computing Through Industry Networking

As President of the Biomedical Engineering Society at Arizona State University, Naina has had the opportunity to host events to boost interest in computing within the Biomedical Engineering community, including an Industry Networking Night that brought together companies to speak to students from all backgrounds about available internships and career opportunities. Naina also secured BMES' first corporate sponsorship with BD and hosted collaborative events with multiple student organizations featuring industry speakers presenting the latest technological breakthroughs in medicine. Through these initiatives, she aims to create greater accessibility and awareness of computer science in both Biomedical Engineering and the greater engineering community to better prepare students for the central role that computing has and will continue to play in our lives.



Nikita Mullangi (she/her)

Genxl

Nikita co-founded Genxl, a certified NGO focused on empowering future generations through education and technology. Boasting a network of 51,500 students and over 2,100 volunteers, they have established 50 global chapters, certified over 5,000,000 volunteer hours, and collaborated with industry giants such as Apple, Google, and Replit. Genxl's initiatives, including speaker series and summits, aim to inspire and equip youth with the skills needed to excel in computing and beyond. Genxl is driven by the belief that access to technology and education can transform lives and strives to create opportunities for all, particularly in underrepresented communities.



Karina Naranjo (she/her)

Vaquerita Ingeniera

Karina led initiatives like the StreetCode Academy Community Rental Tech Distribution Program, where she provided refurbished laptops to underrepresented communities and developed an educational curriculum in tech. As the Vice President of the Silicon Valley LatinaGeeks chapter, Karina focuses on fostering partnerships and coordinating events that support Latinas in tech. Her efforts aim to bridge the digital divide, promote diversity in the tech industry, and empower women through initiatives like Vaquerita Ingeniera, a lifestyle brand; inspired by the need for representation, the brand motivates women to seize opportunities in the tech industry and beyond.



Chikanma Okisor (she/her)

Aspire United Education

Growing up in Nigeria, learning coding and robotics were luxuries as Chikanma taught herself online using Sololearn and an ELEGOO bot her aunt shipped from America. Her nonprofit has been an avenue for Chikanma to give back to her home, along with other communities, and show people that their citizenship does not limit their ability to pursue interests in STEM. Aspire United Education aims to amplify the voice of technology and computing as the backbone of our future.



Manasvi Perisetty (she/her)

Empowering Women in ECE: Connecting Students with the Semiconductor Industry

Manasvi Perisetty is an Electrical and Computer Engineering major at the University of Texas at Austin who strives to increase representation and inclusion in her field. As Vice President of Women in ECE, she recognized the hesitation among women to engage with top semiconductor companies due to a lack of awareness about diverse career paths in the industry. Partnering with the Women at Apple - Austin group, she organized events that facilitated open dialogue and networking between students and industry professionals. These initiatives have helped demystify career paths and encouraged women to explore the full potential of their ECE degrees.



Isabelle Qi (she/her)

Linguistics | WiSTEM Central NJ

Inspired by her own interest in linguistics as well as the success stories of prominent minority figures in STEM like Fei Fei Li, Isabelle founded and serves as the President of Linguistics | WiSTEM Central NJ, an organization geared towards encouraging female, nonbinary, and genderqueer students interested in linguistics, computing, and STEM. Members learn about computational linguistics, computer science, natural language processing, artificial intelligence, and more through regular workshops, guest speakers, and seminars. Isabelle has also spearheaded Linguistics | WiSTEM partnerships with professors and industry professionals from Yale, UPenn, Dartmouth, Amazon, and Facebook, among others.



Caitlin Riordan (she/her)

Environmental Engineering for Everyone

Caitlin sees engineering as an exciting and efficient tool for expanding what is possible in problem-solving across all disciplines. For years, she has enjoyed furthering her progress in innovating sustainable solutions through research heavily dependent upon computing. By organizing Bridging the Gap conferences, Sustainability Celebration events, workshops for historically marginalized youth, and science experiment sessions with local preschools, Caitlin is increasing STEM accessibility and inspiring others to apply computing while innovating solutions to societal problems.



Sara Rosenman (she/her)

STEM Learning – Student Driven

Sara's passion for real-world learning began in fourth grade and led her to personally contact the CEOs and senior management of dozens of large companies across numerous industries throughout the world, in addition to politicians, musicians, investment leaders, and scientists. The positive feedback and opportunities that followed inspired her to help other students. Seeing the disparity between students with and without real-world skills, Sara has created and taught STEM-focused lesson plans and assignments which have been required in numerous



grades and classrooms over the last three years. She has been invited to speak on the topic of real-world learning in schools, and she collaborates with various organizations to further her work in education.

Julia Rosenman (she/her)

STEM Learning – Student Driven

Since she was in fourth grade, Julia has written or called the CEOs and senior management of dozens of large companies (including Fortune 500 and 100 companies), as well as government officials, authors, television personalities, and technologists – all in an attempt to learn more about their careers, career paths, and the life lessons that they learned. The resulting opportunities, which included learning in over thirty areas of the medical device company Boston Scientific, led Julia to create and teach STEM-focused real-world learning and professional skills lesson plans and assignments; these have been required in numerous grades and classes over the last three years. She has been invited to speak on the topic of real-world learning in schools and collaborates with organizations to further her work in education.



Anshita Saini (she/her)

Wiser AI

Anshita is the founder of Wiser AI. As an engineer at OpenAI, she's a strong advocate for gender-inclusive AI practices. Wiser AI brings together marginalized genders in technology who are passionate about shaping ethical and responsible AI. She's previously served as the Founder and President of Code4Care and Vice President of She Codes Art, promoting diversity in CS by leading over 100 outreach workshops and conferences impacting 2,000+ students.



Jenny Sand (she/her)

Building an Inclusive STEM Community

Jenny impacts her community by sharing her passion for coding and technology with her peers and helping young women find interest in the field she loves. To achieve this, Jenny has taught STEM classes, run STEM-related events like Hackathons, started a SWENext club, and has become a Code.org computer science ambassador. When she was younger, Jenny did not have a

community of young women interested in STEM, so as a result, she has worked for the past few years to create her own community that is open to everyone who wants to learn about computer science.

Shreya Santhanagopalan (she/her)

WEngineer Inc.

Shreya's community impact initiative, WEngineer, is a nonprofit organization she founded in high school to bridge the STEM education gap in middle schools.

Recognizing the disconnect in STEM education between primary and secondary schools, Shreya created an afterschool program that fosters interest and

proficiency in engineering among young students, particularly those from underrepresented communities. Over the past eight years, WEngineer has grown from a local effort into a structured program that has impacted over 300 students, offering hands-on learning through afterschool programs and summer camps. Inspired by the positive impact on these students, Shreya is committed to encouraging others to pursue computing and STEM careers, striving to create an inclusive and supportive environment where all students can thrive.



Nishka Sharma (she/her)

Youth Mentorship Project

Nishka founded The Youth Mentorship Project, a nonprofit organization aiming to help under-resourced students pursue academia with the help of a mentor. Releasing YMP Match, an AI-powered platform that matches students with mentors, is providing thousands of students around the world access to free or affordable mentorship. Additionally, their internet access initiative aims to not only connect schools but also provide digital education on how to leverage the internet as a learning resource. Collaborating with the United Nations Science Summit, the Society of Women Engineers, Climate and Digital Education in Sierra Leone, Bharat AI Labs, and more, YMP strives to help students pursue computing.



Prisha Shroff (she/her)

Sustainability Stars

Prisha founded Sustainability Stars, an initiative that motivates youth to tackle the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) through innovative educational programs and leadership opportunities. By focusing on skills like problem-solving and project management, this initiative fills a vital need for active youth engagement in global sustainability efforts. Sustainability Stars establishes high school clubs, conducts STEM challenges for younger students, and amplifies youth voices in key forums. The team builds a network of young sustainability advocates through peer mentorship and collaborative leadership, supported by partnerships with educational institutions, NGOs, and local governments to enhance reach and impact.



Saanvi Subramanian (she/her)

Bothell SWENext Founder

Through the Bothell SWENext club, Saanvi consistently organizes and runs community impact initiatives to create opportunities and connect communities, fostering interest in computing for marginalized identities in the computer science and technology space. The club, with a majority of women-identifying students and supportive male and nonbinary members, has grown to over 100 members in just the past year. Bothell SWENext focuses on outreach, mentorship, and career exploration through activities like hackathons, guest speaker events, and workshops. Saanvi is inspired by a desire to create an inclusive environment where students can explore STEM in engaging ways, building skills and confidence to pursue careers in technology.



Sriya Tallapragada (she/her)

GirlsWhoSTEAM Inc.

Sriya founded GirlsWhoSTEAM, a national 501(c)3 education campaign to promote girls' leadership in STEM, public speaking, financial literacy, and career readiness. Sriya engages in curricular activism, hosting regular summer programs and after-school workshops for girls between the ages of 7-13 from historically under-resourced areas. GirlsWhoSTEAM's programs teach various skills in STEM, public speaking, financial literacy, and career readiness through team exercises, professional speakers, hands-on activities, and more. Imagine a world where every girl feels

empowered by their education to pursue fields where women are underrepresented. By leveraging youth volunteers and community partners, she hopes that these programs pave the way for the next generation of female leaders in business, law, and STEM fields.



Helin Taskesen (she/her)

Middle Eastern North African Exchange Mentorship Program (MENA-X)

Throughout middle and high school, Helin participated in different activities, from being a robot operator to participating in research. From these experiences, she realized that even as a young person, she has the power to drive change for underrepresented and underserved



communities. This is when Helin realized the best way to start making change was by empowering and supporting other underrepresented students in the fields of STEAM.

Grace Thomas (she/her)

STEMpoweringHER Foundation

STEMpoweringHER is a student-led organization co-founded by Grace dedicated to inspiring and empowering girls in science, technology, engineering, and mathematics (STEM). Through hands-on activities, workshops, and events, STEMPoweringHER aims to create a supportive community where all students can explore their interests, develop their skills, and pursue their passions in STEM fields. Its mission is to bridge the gender gap in STEM and foster a diverse, inclusive future. As someone with a passion for computer science, particularly cybersecurity and engineering, Grace is a strong advocate for challenging gender stereotypes in these fields to create a more innovative future.



Mariya Tinch (she/her)

Empowering Marginalized Communities Through STEM Education

As a young woman of color in computer science, Mariya is dedicated to empowering marginalized

individuals to use technology for social good. As the founder of Digital Dreamers, she continues to promote STEM engagement on a national scale through donation drives and educational resources. Additionally, as the president of the Women Achieving Leadership and Excellence Club at her school, she has hosted numerous workshops and seminars to facilitate networking and promote gender equity within professional spaces. Mariya is inspired by the important role of technology in modern history and is committed to amplifying the voices of marginalized communities.



Sofia Vasconez (she/her)

Inspiring Underrepresented Voices in Tech

Sofia is passionate about making technology accessible to everyone, especially in underrepresented communities. Through coding workshops, outreach events, and mentoring, she has seen how even a small spark of curiosity can grow into a lifelong passion. She's inspired by the power of diverse voices in tech and the incredible innovations that come when we all have a seat at the table. Sofia's goal is to empower others to explore computing and unlock their potential to shape the future.



Sage Wang (she/her)

Kid Teach Kid

Sage is the founder of Kid Teach Kid, a nonprofit organization and online learning platform with the vision to empower peer learning and peer teaching and serve as a valuable complement to K-12 education. Over the past four years, she has led a talented team of over 30 student instructors who provided high-quality, free online classes, including diverse subjects in computer science and machine learning, impacting thousands of students worldwide. In addition, she organized a variety of educational events featuring world-class speakers in both academia and industries about the emerging trends in computer technology and artificial intelligence.



Cindy Wang (she/her)

Project SOAR & Inisio

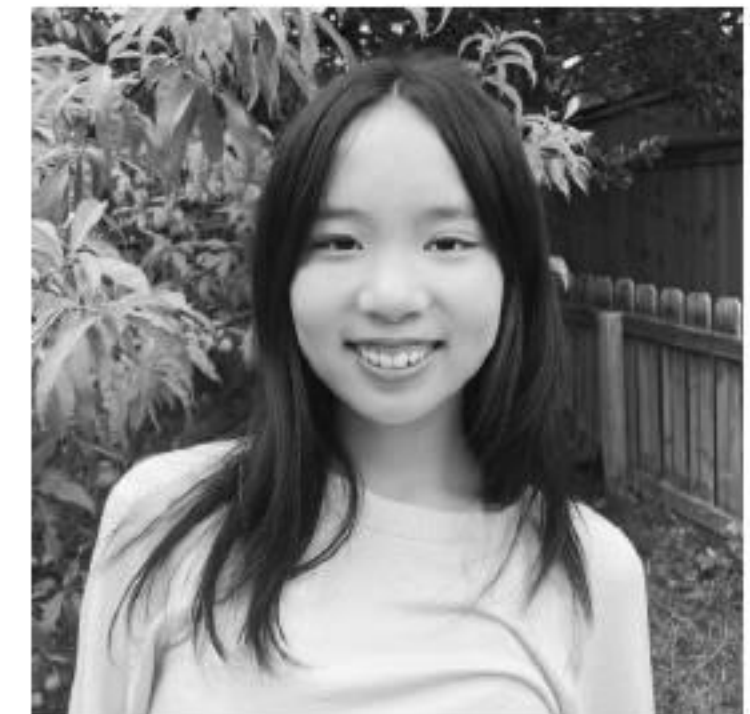
Cindy is a high school student who has been interested in programming since she joined her elementary school's FIRST Lego League Robotics team. Seven years later, she has spearheaded multiple initiatives aiming to equalize access to computing resources and opportunities, especially among underrepresented groups. Compelled by her own experiences in STEM, she hopes to foster an inclusive and welcoming environment in STEM.



Sophia Yang (she/her)

The STEM Spectrum

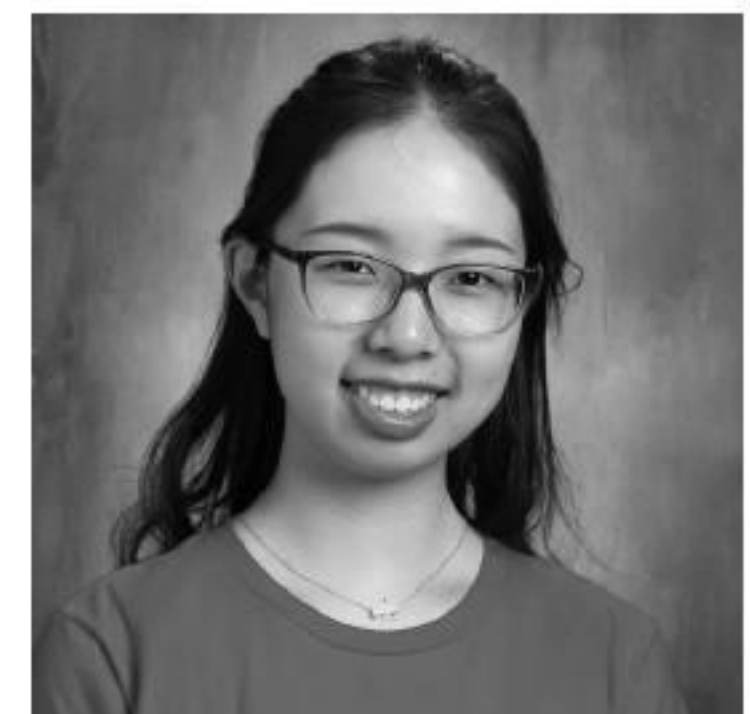
Sophia is the founder of The STEM Spectrum, a STEM education platform that aims to empower youth to drive STEM-based social change to address the world's most pressing issues. The STEM Spectrum offers various programs to accomplish this goal, including an online journal, coding camps for elementary schoolers, and STEM activism petitions. Since its inception, over 1,000,000+ students have been reached, and the journal currently has more than 14,000+ monthly readers.



Sarah Yao (she/her)

FIRST Robotics Competition (FRC) Team Neutrino #3928

As the captain of FIRST Robotics Competition (FRC) Team Neutrino #3928, Sarah is dedicated to fostering the love of STEM that her community has instilled in her. Through outreach events and hosting camps, she ensures that STEM education is accessible to everyone in her community, regardless of their circumstances. Additionally, Sarah serves on the FIRST Iowa Student Leadership board, where she collaborates with peers to organize events promoting STEM on a state-wide level. Her passion for spreading computing and STEM comes from a desire to share the opportunities and experiences that STEM has brought into her own life.



Melody Yin (she/her)

Opportunity X

Melody is president of Opportunity X, a 501(c)(3) nonprofit that provides STEAM opportunities to underrepresented groups. She first became involved with Opportunity X in 8th grade because of her love for research and interest in increasing access to science. Opportunity X's work is primarily split into two branches: weekly science programs in partnership with local lower and middle schools and annual competitions, including an essay contest, science fair, and summer boot camp. Over the past years, she's learned so much from the international science community and looks forward to another amazing year working with them.



Learn about the 2023 NCWIT AiC Impact Award recipients [here](#).

Awardees



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